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Dabur India: Growing Professional Management from Family Roots

What is that life worth which cannot bring comfort to others?

— Dr. S.K. Burman, Founder of Dabur (1884)

On a cool December evening in 2018, Sunil Duggal, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Dabur India Limited, walked out of the company's headquarters in New Delhi, deep in thought. The Dabur office was bustling with activity, but Duggal took little notice of the hubbub around him. As he exited the office building, he glanced over at the towering glass cabinet that showcased Dabur's 250-strong product portfolio. Despite having seen this display countless times, it never ceased to fill him with amazement and pride.

Founded in 1884 by Dr. S.K. Burman as an Ayurvedic^a medicine company, Dabur had produced affordable medical treatments for common ailments, including hair loss, tooth decay, and digestive issues. Over the course of a century, the company had successfully expanded across product categories to become both one of India's largest consumer goods businesses and the largest producer of herbal remedies in the world. By 2018, its products spanned from the Ayurvedic health and personal care industry to the food and beverage industry. In 2018, the company enjoyed revenues of INR. 77.48 billion (USD 1.09 billion), market capitalization of INR 576.02 billion (USD 8.09 billion), and a net profit of INR 1.35 billion (USD 18.97 million).

In the mid-1990s, the Burman family started a program to professionalize the management of the company and step back from doing day-to-day management themselves, but the first attempt to bring in outside managers did not go smoothly. The company suffered its first profit decline in its history in 2001, prompting the family to reassume management responsibility. When they withdrew again upon Duggal's appointment in 2002, he felt the heavy weight of responsibility their trust left on his shoulders. The situation did not improve immediately. Large shifts in the business compromised short-term

^a Ayurveda was a 5,000 year-old system of natural healing based in the ancient Vedic culture of India. The system was widely followed throughout India and was centered on the belief that health and wellness depend on a balance between the mind, body, and spirit. Ayurvedic medicines were formulated using a mix of herbs, oils, spices, and other plant matter.

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profits and caused Dabur's stock price to plummet, but over the course of two years, Duggal streamlined the company's supply chain, imposed financial discipline, implemented an employee stock ownership plan, replaced most of the senior management, and created a management committee to collaboratively make important strategic decisions. Soon enough, Dabur's stock was booming, and the company had a four-year plan in place to continue the growth. By 2005, this meant using strategic acquisitions to establish the company's first footholds in Middle Eastern and African markets, aiming initially to serve the Indian diaspora, but eventually, aiming to serve non-Indian customers as well.

By 2018, Dabur had provided an extended period of high returns to its shareholders (see **Exhibit 1** for stock price performance), and even as the company faced rising competition and foreign exchange headwinds, Duggal felt sure-footed in leading the implementation of the most recent four-year plan, defined by its emphasis on evidence-based Ayurveda. He planned to retire before seeing it through, however, and before he left, he had to ensure a successful transition to the next CEO. Alongside the Board, Duggal had begun to consider candidates for the job. Whoever got the position would need to fully embrace the company's unique values and understand its wide-ranging product portfolio. They would also need to work effectively with the Burman family, who remained Dabur's largest shareholders and had significant board representation.

Consumer Care Products in India

Dabur was among India's top fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies by revenue in 2018, boasting a diverse product portfolio (see **Exhibit 2** for Dabur product lines and **Exhibit 3** for sales breakdown by category).¹ The FMCG category was the fourth-largest sector in the Indian economy, worth USD 52.75 billion in 2017 and quickly expanding.² India's rapid economic growth was raising incomes and leaving consumers more brand-conscious than ever before.³ Within the FMCG market, Dabur was most dominant in the personal care segment on account of its strong value proposition in Ayurvedic products.⁴

The main players in India's FMCG market with similar product portfolios to Dabur's were Hindustan Unilever (HUL), Colgate-Palmolive, Procter & Gamble, and Godrej Consumer Products (see **Exhibit 4** for the Indian FMCG market competitive landscape). HUL, established in 1933 as a subsidiary of the multinational company Unilever, was the market leader by revenue. Following HUL were Colgate-Palmolive and Procter & Gamble, two other multinational companies. Godrej Consumer Products was established in 2001 as a subsidiary of the Godrej Group, an Indian conglomerate with businesses ranging from real estate development to groceries.⁵

In 2016, however, a new entrant called Patanjali Ayurved threatened Dabur in its key niche of Ayurvedic personal care and food products. Patanjali, founded in 2006 by celebrity yogi Baba Ramdev, prided itself on a portfolio of more than 400 products, ranging from laundry detergent to instant noodles, to anti-ageing cream, which it sold for prices 15 to 20 percent lower than its more established competitors. As a result, Patanjali had quickly become the fastest-growing company in the Indian consumer sector, with sales reaching roughly USD 1.25 billion in the fiscal year ending in March 2018.⁶ More favorably for Dabur, however, Patanjali had greatly increased Indian demand for Ayurvedic products as a quintessentially Indian path to health and wellness, steeped in traditional values.⁷

Dabur and the Burman family

Dr. S.K. Burman, an Ayurvedic physician from Bengal in the eastern part of India, founded Dabur in 1884 to promote the natural medicines he produced. "Dabur," in fact, was derived from the Hindi

abbreviation of doctor (“da-aa”), combined with the first syllable of Burman. Dr. Burman’s goal for the company was to provide affordable natural treatments to populations with limited access to conventional medicine. The effectiveness of the products helped build Dr. Burman’s reputation, and soon enough, in 1896, Dabur opened its first manufacturing facility.⁸

Over time, the company grew, and at each step of the way, members of the Burman family shepherded it forward. In 1919, Dr. Burman’s son, C.L. Burman, established Dabur’s first research and development unit and expanded its manufacturing capacity. His two sons took over the company in the 1930s and divided the responsibility of running the business between them. Of particular note, they established the company’s first foothold in the personal care space by launching the popular Amla hair oil in 1940.⁹ At that time, all seven Burman families spanning three generations shared a home in Calcutta next door to the company’s head offices. Leadership in the company was passed down via a mentoring process in which an uncle guided each male heir through an introduction to the business operations. The lines between family matters and company matters were blurry. As Dr. Anand Burman, C.L. Burman’s great grandson (see **Exhibit 5** for Burman family tree), reminisced:

[T]he lunch table discussion, the dinner table discussion—everything was something to do with the business. “This happened today, and that happened yesterday”—and so you got a feeling about exactly what was going on in the business, and in the family of course. They were completely inseparable at that time, and rightly so...¹⁰

In spite of its growth, however, in many ways, Dabur remained a family company. In the 1950s, for instance, even though the company was larger and growing quickly, its quality control lab was still located in the Burman family house in Calcutta. When Dr. Anand Burman was growing up, the family lived on one floor of the house, and the rest of the floors were dedicated to business functions; the company’s head offices next door were connected to the house by a bridge.¹¹

In the 1960s, fourth-generation Vivek Burman began to run advertisements for Dabur products, at first on the radio and later on the television, populated by Indian film personalities. In addition, the family used small airplanes to shower popular fairs with pamphlets and sent employees on elephants draped in product banners through remote areas of the country (see **Exhibit 6** for Dabur advertising campaigns). These advertising campaigns established Dabur as a household name in both urban and rural markets, and in order to ensure that customers attracted by its advertisements would never be greeted with an empty shelf, Dabur made significant investments in its distribution infrastructure as well. Over time, it built its local sales force, village by village, across India.¹²

Throughout the 1970s, Dabur continued to increase its manufacturing and research and development capacities, releasing Ayurvedic digestive aids and herbal toothpowders that would come to be used daily by around 25 million people across India.¹³ In 1972, it relocated its headquarters to New Delhi.

In 1994, Dabur became publicly listed, using the capital it raised to finance a significant expansion. During this period in the early 1990s, a number of policy reforms liberalizing India’s economy were creating new opportunities for business in the country, and Dabur sought to seize on those opportunities as a chance to grow. Accordingly, in 1993, Dabur ventured into cancer treatment by introducing the drug Ixatel, and in 1996, it established a food and beverage division with the launch of Real Fruit Juices.¹⁴ Between 1992 and 1995, it also took advantage of India’s new economic openness by initiating strategic partnerships with a number of foreign consumer goods companies, including a Spanish chewing gum business, a French cheesemaker, and an Israeli snack food producer. This, however, prompted some to question whether Dabur’s burgeoning business mix was leading it away from its Ayurvedic roots.

Professionalization at Dabur

In the mid-1990s, as this expansion was taking off, the family patriarch, Mr. A.C. Burman, began to realize that their fifth-generation family business was fast-outgrowing its family model. As a result, the family (which then owned 79 percent of the stock) decided to professionalize the organization by inducting non-family members into the senior executive ranks, a novel move, especially for an Indian family business of Dabur's size. Nonetheless, the limitations of family management had begun to show. At the time, eight different members of the Burman family's fourth and fifth generations occupied senior roles at the company, and as Dr. Anand Burman explained, "Once you start cutting across not only generations but also across sections of the family, differences of opinion are bound to emerge." In addition, there was the challenge to hold the senior leadership accountable for performance because, as Dr. Anand Burman put it, "You can't fire family members when they don't perform." Finally, it had become clear that Dabur's executive suite lacked essential expertise for a rapidly growing FMCG business in the competitive marketplace that India was fast becoming.

In the mid-1990s, Dabur hired McKinsey, the global management consulting firm, to develop a strategic plan for the company. As McKinsey evaluated Dabur's business units and performance across verticals, it suggested to the Dabur leadership that a majority of family businesses failed to survive beyond three generations and that professionalization of management was necessary for a family firm's long-term survival. Though some in the family already had an inkling that the time for professionalization had come, others needed to hear it from management experts in order to be convinced. As Mohit Burman, a director at Dabur, recalled, "This was big news. Leadership in Indian companies was traditionally passed from father to son to grandson, irrespective of merit, no questions asked." For his part, Dr. Anand Burman described the family's conversations with McKinsey about professionalization as follows:

[T]hey asked a fairly simple question: "Just because your last name is Burman, does that mean you are the best managers in the world?" Which sort of resonated with pretty much everybody. McKinsey suggested that one of the ways to bring value to the corporation would be to separate the ownership from the management and get the best person to do a particular job. So if somebody needs to look after supply chain, or somebody needs to be a brand manager, or marketing manager, or the CEO—you need to get the best person for the job, which made perfect sense.¹⁵

Consequently, professional managers took over running Dabur. Duggal himself was very much a part of that, but more significantly, between 1997 and 1999, the entire executive suite was replaced with senior managers from multinational, blue chip companies. Dabur had a new CEO, a new CFO, and they were all hired from outside.

When the new management took control, the company had been doing well. As Duggal put it:

This professionalization agenda wasn't a cry for help. This was a strange situation in which change came as the company was flourishing. Normally, people aren't motivated to do something like this until there's a crisis, but here, we had a healthy ship with a great market cap and a fair amount of investor respect, and the family decided to use that as an opportunity to turn things over.

The family, then, built an office for itself in New Delhi, 50 kilometers away from Dabur's headquarters. The only family member who continued to maintain an office in the corporate building was G.C. Burman, then Managing Director and Vice Chairman of the Board, who was charged with helping the new CEO manage the transition. As Dr. Anand Burman explained, "If we remained at

headquarters, nobody was going to listen to the management. People would still come to us and all the decisions would pass through us. Now that we had decided to professionalize, people had to know that we would not be around.”

The Burman family realized that professionalization had to extend to the Board, as well, if it were to be fully effective. Accordingly, they reached out to renowned industrialists, retired bureaucrats, lawyers, bankers and accountants about the prospect of their joining the Board. Ultimately, several did, and the Board immediately post-professionalization consisted of twelve directors: four from the family, two executive directors, and six independent directors. New committees were established, and the independent directors were empowered to exercise oversight over all major corporate decisions.

By 1999, the Burman family's direct influence in the company was through its representatives on the Board, though in addition, it still owned 79 percent of Dabur's stock. After the company went public, the descendants of Dr. S.K. Burman's two grandsons, P.C. Burman and R.C. Burman, divided that 79 percent of company shares still left in promoter hands equally between the two branches of the family, leaving each branch with around 40 percent. They later further diluted their holdings down to 75 percent to comply with a regulatory requirement on promoter stakes in Indian public companies (mandating a 25 percent public float), and from there, over time, they diluted them again down to around 68 percent to fund various private investments (see **Exhibit 7** for the composition of Dabur's shareholder base over time). Crucially, however, no family member could liquidate his or her holdings of Dabur stock without first offering them to the other family members, a provision aimed at maintaining a concentrated family stake in the company.

To organize the family ownership post-professionalization, the Burman family created a Family Council in 2000. The Council was composed of all male members of the family over the age of 25, and its purpose was to formalize family governance processes that had existed on a more informal basis for the previous century of Dabur's history. To this end, the Council penned a family constitution specifying everything from dividend policies to succession processes, though as time passed, the Council came to serve more as a forum for the family to receive updates on Dabur and discuss their own ventures.

The only non-Burman family member involved in the Family Council was P.D. Narang, a longtime and trusted advisor of the family. Narang, a chartered accountant and the company secretary, joined Dabur in 1979 as a manager and played a pivotal role in Dabur's transition to (partial) public ownership, as well as in its professionalization. In 2003, Narang was the Group Director for Corporate Affairs and had served for a number of years on the Board of Directors. Commenting on his role, Narang remarked: “I proved to be an important intermediary between the Management Committee, the Board, and the Family Council representing the Burmans.” He continued:

I used to come to Mr. Burman's house and sit with him for two to three hours, brief him, get his guidance, and go in the next day to work, so I interacted very frequently with both the family and the management. He would give me the feedback of the entire family, which I in turn would relay to the management. I chaired the Management Committee for the first two years, from 2002 to 2004, but my role today is to go to the Management Committee meetings whenever the stakes of a decision exceed a certain value.

Difficulties with the Transition

Ninu Khanna was appointed as Dabur's first professional CEO in late 1998. He had previously held senior positions at Colgate-Palmolive and Procter & Gamble. Shortly thereafter, the company started

hiring younger professionals with MBAs from top business schools, replacing long-tenured members of the management team. This led a number of the remaining managers who had long histories with the company to resign. Between that and G.C. Burman's passing in 2001, the top ranks of the company were in a state of significant flux. This undermined the quality of managerial decision-making throughout the company just as, for the first time in the company's history, the family had stepped back and given the management reins to professionals. As a result, in 2001, the company saw stagnating sales, a plummeting stock price (from a high of INR 175 in January 2000 to INR 46 in December 2001), and its first annual loss since its founding.¹⁶ In Dr. Anand Burman's words, "Dabur was in turmoil and things were spiraling out of control."

In response, the Burman family resumed a hands-on approach to supervising the business. V.C. Burman, the Chairman of the Board since G.C. Burman's passing, along with a few other family members, began looking much more closely into managerial decisions, which led to Khanna's resignation at the end of 2001. Duggal recalled, "There was a wholesale departure of top management, people who had come in from outside. Except for one or two persons, everybody including the CEO were let go." For the following several months, the company was run by the family again.

Sunil Duggal as CEO

Sunil Duggal came to Dabur in 1995 from PepsiCo, where he had worked in a managerial role in Pepsi Foods. He had an undergraduate degree in electrical engineering from the Birla Institute of Technology & Science, Pilani and an MBA from the Indian Institute of Management, Calcutta. When Duggal was first approached about joining Dabur, he was not entirely sold on the idea. He recalled, "I was very ambivalent when they reached out because it was a family-run company, so the space for a professional seemed to be limited." However, he also saw a number of advantages to the business:

I thought it's a great company, great portfolio, and I liked the idea of joining an Indian company. I believe that in an Indian company you can do more, you can innovate more, you can do more of your own thing. After having worked with multinationals, in a sense you have to follow a lot of templates, and there are restraints that Indian companies don't have.

As a result, when the then-Chairman, Mr. A.C. Burman, explained to him that Dabur was seeking to professionalize and that it would be hiring McKinsey to advise on the transition, Duggal was persuaded to give it a shot. He joined the company as a general manager in the personal care business, working primarily on sales and marketing, but he rose quickly, buoyed by the personal care business's strong performance. In 1998, he was promoted to Vice President for Sales and Marketing, and in 2000, he was appointed to Dabur's board as an executive director.¹⁷

In April of 2002, the Burman family asked Duggal to take over as CEO. As Duggal explained it:

My business fortunately was doing well, the only business that was doing well. I worked closely with them, trying to identify and resolve problems. And one fine Sunday, they said, "Okay, you come to the office on Monday and take over. On Tuesday, we will stop coming." I said, "Just like that?" They said, "Yes, just like that. We have made the decision, and we are committed to it. If we remain in that office nobody will listen to you, so we have to leave." So I was kind of plunged into the hot seat, and the company was still in a desperately bad situation.

The beginning of Duggal's time as CEO was challenging. As competition from cash-rich multinationals was hitting the Indian FMCG market, Dabur was weighed down by a dated product portfolio. In spite of its strong brand recognition, it was struggling to keep up. Duggal reminisced, "My first year was very turbulent because I had to clean up all the sins of the past, and my view was that if I didn't clean them up then, they would haunt me for the rest of my tenure. So I ripped off the bandage; we took massive hits in terms of P&L, and the investors were furious."

It was clear to Duggal at the time that turning the company around required refreshing much of the senior management, which contributed to the difficulty of the transformation effort. Duggal explained, "I did a lot of the recruitment myself: the head of procurement, head of operations, CFO, supply chain head, and a couple of others. We formed a great team and that team really helped move the company forward." He added, "I brought in people who had passion and were committed to doing something much bigger than what they had been doing in their earlier jobs. I found people who were hungry for growth. They were willing to do anything to build their careers in a different environment. They were the people that made the difference."¹⁸

After refreshing the management, Duggal created a management committee to make important managerial decisions. He explained, "The CEO is not omniscient, so decision-making must be collaborative rather than top-down." After developing an initial sales strategy aimed at overcoming some of the challenges then hitting the Indian FMCG market, the new management team began to develop four-year strategic roadmaps. This then led to the creation of annual budgets and quarterly budget reviews, the introduction of standard operating procedures, and other big steps toward properly professionalizing the way Dabur was run.

Other changes during that period aimed to align incentives of people inside the company and improve corporate governance. For instance, the company initiated an employee stock ownership plan, and the Burman family members, even those on the board of directors, decided to stop taking salaries and perks. The Family Council, in fact, amended their claim to salaries and perks out of its constitution, which Duggal thought was important to maintaining a high degree of dedication on the part of the management.

Dabur after 2002

Dabur underwent significant strategic changes throughout Duggal's tenure as CEO. As a result of these changes, the company passed the one billion dollar turnover mark in 2011-2012 and grew its market capitalization from INR 17 billion in 2001 (USD 360 million) to INR 170 billion in 2010 (USD 3.7 billion) (see **Exhibits 8 and 9** for Dabur's financials from 1999 to 2018).

Key Strategic Shifts

International Growth Historically, Dabur had focused on serving the domestic Indian market, but it had access to a potentially lucrative market of Indians living overseas. Dabur's global reach expanded gradually. It started out with a franchise selling Dabur personal care products in Dubai. Duggal realized over the course of a number of trips to the Middle East that though this business served a customer base consisting almost exclusively of Indian expatriates, it had significant potential for growth. Consequently, in 2005, Dabur's board decided to acquire the franchise and expand it with professional managers from Dabur's Indian business.

By 2006, Dabur had established six plants overseas, and by 2011, that number had risen to 17. The company localized its supply chain, building factories in the United Arab Emirates, Egypt, Nepal, Sri

Lanka, Bangladesh and Nigeria. Duggal elaborated, “This decision paid off – our products soon became favorites with Arab customers and our international business became a strong growth engine for the company, helping it tide over the recession, when it hit the domestic market.”¹⁹ Next, in 2010, Dabur moved into Turkey by acquiring Hobi Kozmetik Group, a Turkish personal care company. The aim of the acquisition was to allow Dabur to develop a presence in Turkey selling products related to its core competencies under brands that would be recognized by Turkish consumers. That same year, Dabur acquired Namaste Laboratories, a U.S.-based producer of hair products for women of African descent. Dabur aimed to use it as a platform to access markets across Sub-Saharan Africa, where Namaste’s products were popular among more affluent consumers.

Brand Building and Diversification Through the 2000s, Dabur diversified its product portfolio and built new brands across a number of different segments. The company both aimed to refresh its existing product lines and to enter several new areas with strong secular growth prospects, like skin care and packaged sales. As a result of these initiatives, new products accounted for between five and seven percent of annual sales revenue throughout the period.²⁰

Dabur accomplished a portion of this through strategic acquisitions. In 2005, Dabur acquired Balsara Hygiene and Home Products business in an all-cash deal.²¹ At the time, Dabur’s only oral care product, Red Toothpaste, had limited reach, as it appealed almost exclusively to people interested in Ayurveda. With its multiple toothpaste brands, including Promise, Babool, and Meswak, Balsara filled that gap. Dabur also bought Odomos and Odonil, both insect repellent businesses, and in 2008, it acquired a 72.15 percent stake in Fem Care Pharma, a women’s skin care company with strong positioning in lightening treatments, hair removal products, and liquid soap. To take further advantage of anticipated growth in demand for skin care products, Dabur launched the OxyLife Professional Facial Kit in 2011.

By 2012, Dabur’s product portfolio included five distinct flagship brands: Hajmola (digestives), Fem (skin care), Vatika (premium personal care), Real (fruit juices), and Dabur (a master brand for natural healthcare products). Dabur invested heavily in advertising to build these flagship brands, arranging for each to be endorsed by popular film stars. It also established an extensive distribution network, covering six million retail outlets across India. Through these investments, several of Dabur’s brands became “billion rupee brands.” By 2015, Dabur had 14 brands that generated annual sales of INR one billion (USD 15.6 million) and three brands that generated annual sales of more than INR ten billion (USD 156 million). In 2015, Dabur entered the premium baby care market with the launch of Dabur Baby, offering a range of baby care products, including massage oil prepared using natural ingredients.²²

Dabur continued to innovate, seeking to accommodate consumers’ growing preference to use products free of synthetic chemicals. In 2012, it re-launched its hair care brand Vatika with premium natural ingredients. In 2013, it launched a new line of healthy fruit beverages under its Real Activ brand, India’s first all-natural toothpaste, and an all-natural skin bleach, containing saffron, milk, and vitamin E. Finally, in 2014, it expanded its packaged food business with the launch of 100-percent natural coconut water that did not contain any added sugar or preservatives.²³

Procurement and Distribution Duggal also shepherded Dabur through significant changes in procurement and distribution. In 2003, it became the first Indian FMCG company to adopt e-procurement. This substantially reduced costs by allowing almost half of its raw materials by value to be sourced online. Later, in 2006, the company launched a retail strategy program called “DARE.” The purpose of the program was twofold. First, by dividing up the company’s 600,000 retailers by type, it allowed Dabur to maximize efficiency channel by channel. Second, it gave Dabur access to consumer

data through partnerships with large retailers, like Spencer's and Big Bazaar. In 2007, Dabur moved into direct retailing by launching the retail chains H&B Stores and NewU. These stores, which were located primarily in upscale malls, sold a wide range of Dabur beauty products, and in 2011, the firm became the first Indian FMCG company to launch a dedicated online shopping portal for its line of beauty products.²⁴

Duggal and the Burman Family

Strong results helped Duggal quickly gain the trust of the family. He reflected:

As luck would have it the company started doing extraordinarily well, and we had great years from 2002 to 2015. Shortly after appointing me as CEO, the family took a step back. They saw the initial results; they saw that things are on the right track; they also saw that their being there would be a distraction, so they left and went back to their family office. They never lost faith in what we were doing.

Narang agreed, saying:

Now, the family has so much confidence in the CEO because every four years, the company doubles its market cap. Four years ago, the market cap was 300 billion rupees [USD 5.1 billion]. Now, it's 610 billion rupees [USD 9.6 billion]. And profitable growth is the objective, so the family oversees things, but they leave the strategic decisions to the management.

This trust, Duggal thought, was built on a foundation of transparency and engagement in good faith. He explained, "We [the management] don't play any tricks. We encourage the family directors to sit in on business reviews. We tell them all that is happening – the good things and bad things. We seek their opinion, and if we think there is merit in it, we definitely implement it. We keep them in the loop always, as that creates trust."²⁵ Duggal was frank with the Burman family when necessary. For instance, in the case of Dabur's international business, which was run by the Burmans for some time after the initial period of professionalization, Duggal believed it would perform better under the corporate umbrella, so he asked the family to relinquish control of it to the company. As he put it, "When I feel that there is value that I can unlock, I can be pretty blunt about demanding it." Duggal explained that the relationship between the family and a professional had to be a two-way street, with each party doing its best to accommodate the other. While the family needed to be willing to yield power to the professionals, professionals too needed to be sensitive to the company's long-held values and norms.²⁶

Mohit Burman explained the family's perspective on Dabur's professional management as follows:

Our main objective was always the company, so when we saw the company growing healthily with the business in professional hands, our view changed. We realized that although it was important to us to stay in control of the business over the long-term, it was not necessary for us to be employed by the business. And if we were, it would have become like: Every father thinks his son is the best, so who chooses who should run the company and who should not? To avoid any sort of conflict, then, it was decided that no family member would have an executive role. And we all stopped getting salaries from Dabur; no family member was getting a salary. We did all these things to show the investor community that we had high standards of corporate governance, and because we own 70 percent of the company, we weren't really worried about losing control of the business.

Amit Burman framed the decision from a recruiting and retention standpoint, noting:

If you decide as a family that you want to professionalize the company, the professionals should see that. They should know that you mean what you're saying, that it's not going to be professionalization in name only. And that's how you attract talent too. Otherwise, you will not get the best in the business.

As a result of all of this, Duggal had a substantial degree of autonomy in how he ran the company. As Narang explained it:

The family have not, to their credit, been interfering in the day-to-day management of the company, and they don't have power of attorney to issue any check or place any orders or appoint people or buy any equipment, so they cannot interfere. That's why I guess it has worked with this model. They give their feedback, but decision-making is left with the Management Committee.

Dr. Anand Burman added an example from his time as Chairman of the Board to illustrate the hands-off relationship between the Burman family and Dabur's management, describing the following instance in 2009:

The Family Council will never say, "Do not launch this product" – that's part of the management's job. As a matter of fact, I was sitting in a review meeting several years ago—we have quarterly reviews which we attend—and the management was about to launch a new product, a new variant of Hajmola. So they brought it out and said, "You must try this." So I had one, and I said "This is terrible, why would you launch this?" The reply I got back made me feel really proud. They said, "Sir, you are not the target audience." That shut me up real quick, and it made me feel good that, look, here is a team that is so confident in its belief about that product that it is ready to go ahead.²⁷

The product in question, a candy, was launched shortly thereafter and was an enormous success, garnering record sales in its first year on the market.²⁸ Narang offered a similar story:

We bought a toothpaste brand called Binaca, and we have not used it since the acquisition. It had been available, and it was cheap, so we bought it. But then, we decided not to launch it because we already had five toothpaste brands. The family questioned why we hadn't rolled it out. They said, "You have such a beautiful brand in Binaca. Why don't you launch it? At least test it out – do a pilot." When I brought this feedback to the management, however, our marketing experts told us that it was a bad idea, that we already had too many toothpaste brands on the market, and we needed to consolidate. Colgate only had one brand, and that brand was more recognizable because more people purchased it. So we didn't launch Binaca.

The Roles of the Board of Directors and the Family Council

In 2018, Dabur's board consisted of twelve members: the Chairman, four non-executive family directors, two executive directors, and six non-executive independent directors (see **Exhibits 10 and 11** for Dabur's board members). The four family board seats were divided equally across the two branches of the Burman family, and the chairmanship was determined by consensus but rotated across the two branches.²⁹ The board exercised essential oversight over corporate decisions. Duggal explained that he could only make decisions with a financial impact of up to INR 100 million (USD 1.4 million) without

Board approval. Any more than that, and he had to run them by the Board. Amit Burman described the oversight exercised by the family directors on the Board as follows:

We get into a lot of strategic decisions. We have quarterly meetings, quarterly reviews – we dedicate at least two weeks every quarter to reviewing the business, to strategizing, to looking at different markets and different product lines and what we can do with the business. So I think that family touch is still there. The professional managers listen to our ideas, and they consider them, but again, it's their decision at the end of the day.

He also noted instances in which the family directors provided input outside of the boardroom context:

If there is something outside of what we have budgeted for – for example, new M&A – then we'll spend a lot of time on that. Or if there is capex that was not in the budget, then again, we'd get together to look at why, what, how... If there is any issue that Sunil wants to raise, we'll meet up. So when demonetization happened, we were meeting quite often to look at the repercussions of that and how to mitigate them. And similarly, for the Goods and Services Tax, we again kept meeting; we had to sort how to move forward. We want to make these decisions collectively. But other than the quarterly reviews, it's all on an as-needed basis.

In addition to serving on Dabur's board, the four Burman family directors also pursued other business projects. Saket Burman advised a number of angel investing funds and sat on the board of several companies.³⁰ Mohit Burman, for his part, worked for a number of years at Dabur Finance on asset management, life insurance, and pension services, which led to his overseeing Aviva plc's 2002 entrance into the Indian life insurance market as part of a joint venture with Dabur. Subsequently, he was involved with the company Punjab Tractors, of which he was a part owner, worked as a managing director at the Indian private equity fund Elephant Capital, and sat on a number of other corporate boards.³¹ He was also the co-owner of an Indian Premier League cricket team Kings XI Punjab. Amit Burman, after some time working in internal strategy consulting at Colgate-Palmolive, went on to lead Dabur's foray into processed foods in the 1990s, serving as CEO of Dabur Foods from 1999 to 2007, when Dabur Foods was merged with Dabur India. In the years that followed, he was appointed Vice Chairman of Dabur India's board and served as a director on the boards many other companies.³² Finally, Dr. Anand Burman, the Chairman of Dabur's board, served on a wide array of other corporate boards and was the managing director of Dabur Oncology plc U.K.³³

The Burman family also helped steward the business through the Family Council. Amit Burman explained:

After each board meeting, we have a family meeting, which lasts for a couple of hours, and a large part of that meeting is spent informing the family members who are not on the board about what happened in the board meeting. We review the business's performance that quarter with them, so they all know what's happening and can ask questions. And Sunil is around if there are questions that I can't answer or Doc [Anand Burman] can't answer.

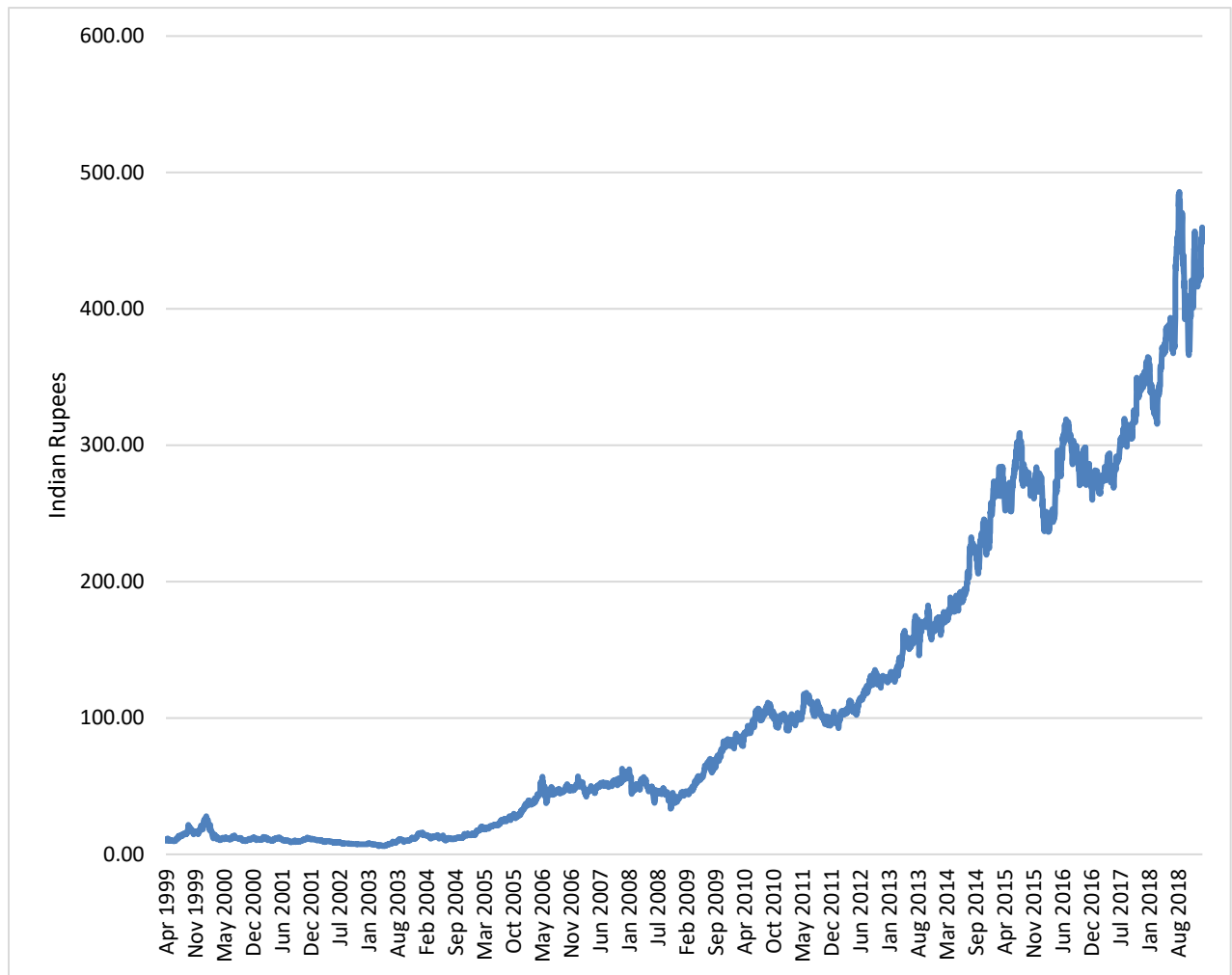
Narang elaborated:

During the Family Council meetings, I brief the family members who don't sit on the board, and then I and the four family board members answer questions. The family is usually concerned about growth and profitability. The company has a dividend policy of

paying out 50 percent of earnings. Sometimes, they ask us questions about how we are benchmarking our performance, about how we compare to other companies, or they give us feedback about entering a particular segment or changing our distributor network in some way. Then, we have to show them the steps we are taking. Sometimes, we call in a manager to give a presentation to help with that.

The Road Ahead

As Duggal looked ahead to 2019, he felt that the company was both doing well and continuing to improve. He remained confident in Dabur's strong brand value, its iron-clad distribution network, and its unique value proposition in Ayurvedic products. Despite stiffer competition from new entrants and established multinationals, Dabur was comfortably a market leader in Indian FMCG. Globally, Dabur was continuing its two-pronged strategy of advancing its existing products while making strategic acquisitions to expand its portfolio. This approach was paying off; the international business had become a strong growth engine for the company. However, as Duggal looked back at Dabur's headquarters and reflected on how far the company had come, he acknowledged that a difficult road lay ahead. He had to identify a successor. But who would replace him? Would it be best to appoint a seasoned Dabur veteran knew the Burman family and their values? Or would it be better to bring in an outsider with a fresh perspective? Though Duggal had considered these questions many times in the past, the time had now come to act.

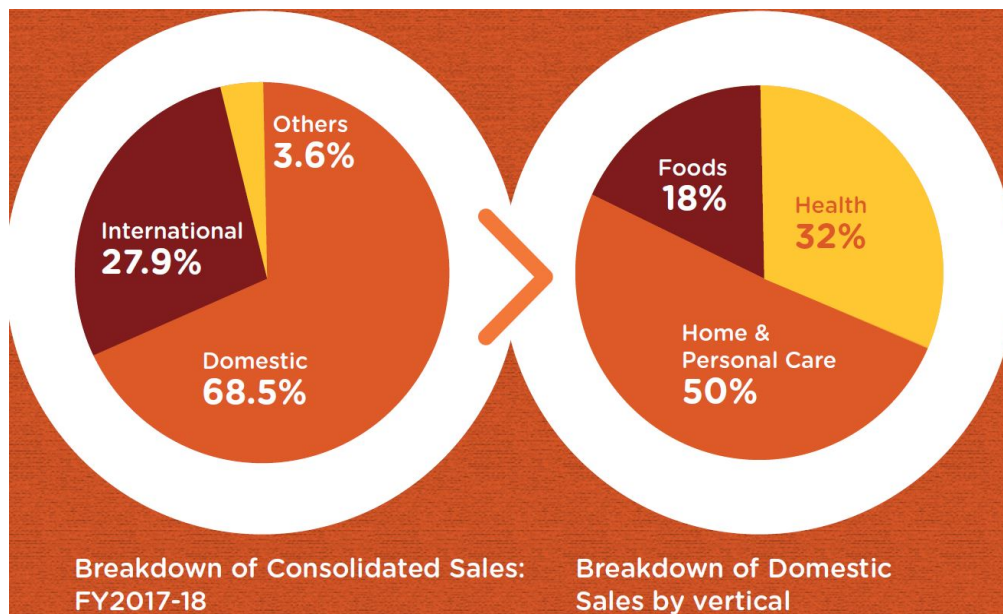
Exhibit 1 Dabur Stock Price (1999-2019)

Source: S&P Capital IQ, Charting, accessed February 2019.

Exhibit 2 Dabur Product Lines (2018)

	Overview	Highlights
Health Care	Diverse and well-trusted portfolio of Ayurveda and Nature-based health supplements, digestives, and over-the-counter products in the Preventive Health Care space.	- Voted as the Most Trusted Ayurveda brand in India for four years running by TRA Research - Chyawanprash Health Supplement 1949: 65% share of Ayurvedic medicine market - Hajmola Digestive Aid 1978: 60% share of digestive tablet market - Dabur Honey 1994: 75% share of branded honey market
Personal Care	Offers a range of nature-based solutions that combine beauty with health and caters to all age groups.	- Amla Hair Oil 1940: largest selling hair oil - Vatika Shampoo 1994: fastest selling shampoo brand - Dabur Red Toothpaste 2004: 14% share of oral care market
Foods	Dabur's fastest growing vertical catering to consumers' increased preference for a healthier lifestyle.	- Real Fruit Juices 1997: 60% share of fruit juice market - Hommade 1996: Pioneer in ready-made cooking-paste segment
Home Care	Newest vertical developing safe and affordable Home Care solutions for every household.	- Odomos Mosquito Repellent 2009: 85% share in outdoor personal care market - Odopic 2005: 10% share in dishwash detergent market

Source: Company documents, <https://www.dabur.com/img/assets/138-reference-only-dabur-brr-inside.pdf>.

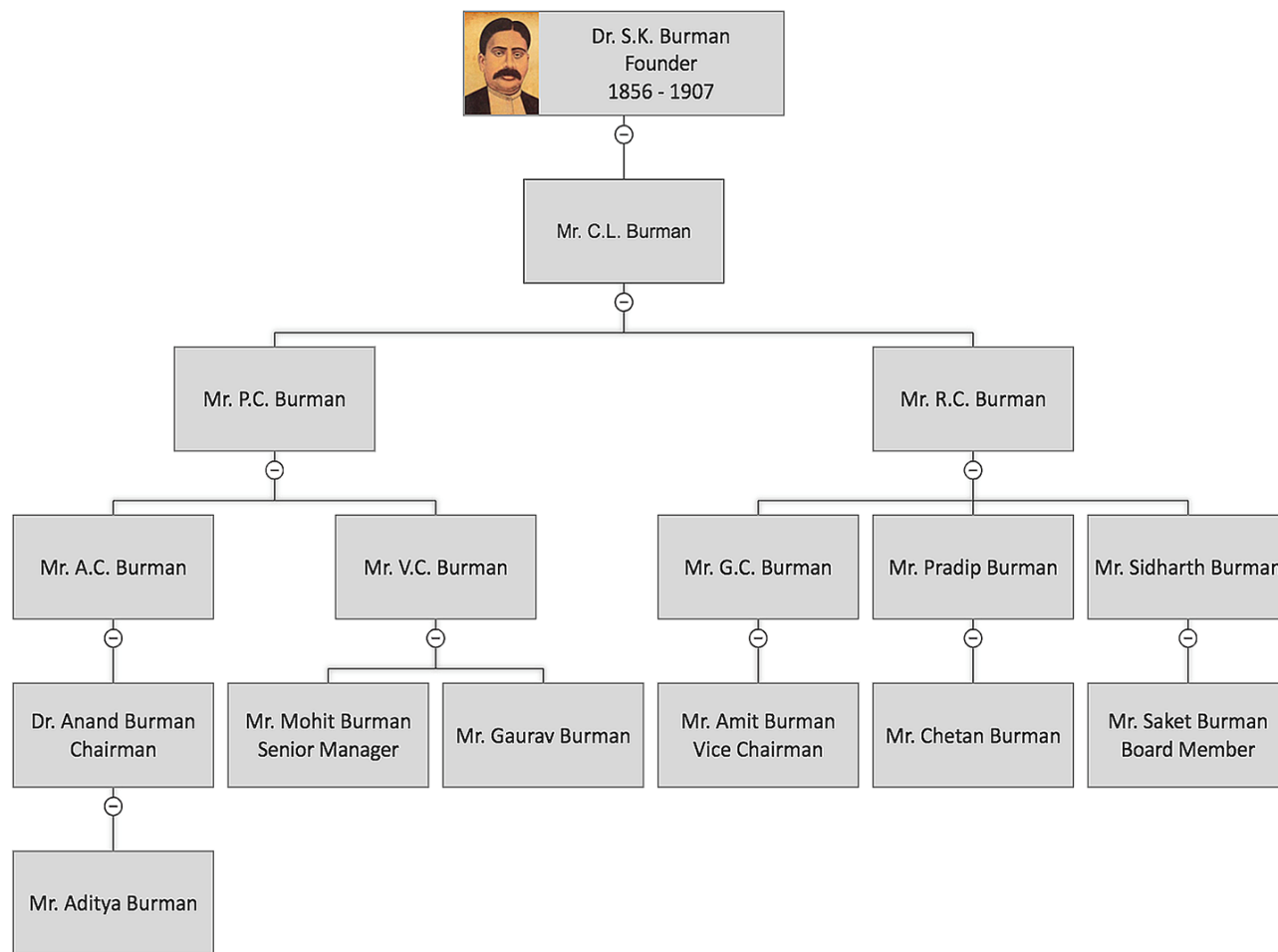
Exhibit 3 Breakdown of Sales (2017-2018)

Source: Dabur India 2017-2018 Annual Report, p. 6, <https://www.dabur.com/in/en-us/investor/financial-information/reports/annual-reports>.

Exhibit 4 India FMCG Market Competitive Landscape

	HUL	Patanjali	Dabur	Godrej CP	Procter & Gamble	Colgate-Palmolive
Established in India	1933	2006	1884	2001	1964	1937
2017 Revenue (\$ million)	4643.92	1512.97	1099.55	738.16	357.42	575.96
Slogan	"Small actions, big difference."	"Prakriti ka aashirwaad."	"Celebrate life."	"Brighter living."	"Touching lives, improving life."	"World of care."
International Presence	190 countries	10 countries	120 countries	80 countries	180 countries	200 countries
Key Product Lines	Dove Personal Care; Lipton Tea; Sunsilk Hair Care; Cif Home Care	Cow's Ghee; Dant Kanti Toothpaste; Keshkanti Shampoo	Amla Hair Oil; Hajmola Digestive Aid; Red Toothpaste; Real Juices	Godrej No. 1 Soaps; Renew Hair Color; Goodknight Repellent	Gillette Shave Care; Olay Creams; Oral-B Oral Care; Pantene Hair Care; Tide Detergents	Colgate Oral Care; Palmolive Soaps; SpeedStick Antiperspirant
Dominant Personal Care Sectors	47% Shampoo; 64% Skin Care	14% Oral Care; 44% Ghee; 50% Honey	19% Hair Oil; 60% Fruit Juice; 14% Oral Care	51% Repellent; 13% Soaps; 25% Hair Color	27% Shampoo	54.9% Oral Care
Strategic Focus	High brand awareness and visibility; Brand campaigns tied to social causes	Heavily discounted Ayurvedic products; Strong brand association with health and Indian heritage; Publicity with Yoga Guru Baba Ramdev	Trusted, science-based Ayurvedic products; Expansive rural distribution network; Aggressive e-commerce strategy to target young consumers	Targets mass consumers with quality products at value prices; Half of revenue from international acquisitions	Higher-cost premium products at modern trade outlets; Perceived to not meet Indian consumers' preferences well	Broad, segmented product portfolio; Established brand equity

Source: Company documents and analysis.

Exhibit 5 Burman Family Tree

Source: Compiled using company documents.

Exhibit 6 Select Dabur Advertising Campaigns

Source: Company documents. Photograph of elephant billboard from Louise Hawson, "52 Suburbs," 2009.



Source: Company documents. Photograph of an old Amla Hair Oil advertisement.



Source: Company documents. Photograph of Dabur Bollywood advertisement.

Exhibit 7 Shareholding in Dabur over Time

Shareholder Type	Percent of Shares Held, 1998	Percent of Shares Held, 2018
Directors, Promoters, and Burman Family Members	79.07%	68.07%
Foreign Institutional/Portfolio Investors	4.42%	17.21%
Mutual Funds	2.51%	4.32%
Financial Institutions, Banks, and Insurance Companies	2.10%	4.21%
Non-Resident Indians and Foreign Nationals	1.30%	0.3%
Indian Public	10.59%	5.20%

Source: Dabur India Annual Reports, <https://www.dabur.com/in/en-us/investor/financial-information/reports/annual-reports>.

Exhibit 8 Dabur Ten-Year Financials (1999-2008)

Dabur Financials (in tens of millions of INR)	FY99	FY00	FY01 ^a	FY02 ^b	FY03	FY04 ^c	FY05	FY06 ^d	FY07 ^e	FY08
Operating Results:										
Sales	863	982	1100	1200	1285	1236	1417	1757	2080	2396
Other Income	23	34	19	12	7	9	9	13	26	34
EBITDA	98	128	137	144	162	164	217	300	376	443
EBITDA Margins (%)	11.3	13	12.5	12	12.6	13.3	15.3	17.1	18.1	18.5
Profit Before Tax (PBT)	52	81	85	82	106	124	176	257	319	384
Taxes	2	4	7	14	14	15	19	30	39	52
Tax Rate (%)	2.9	4.5	8.5	16.6	13.3	12	10.8	11.7	12.1	13.4
Profit After Tax (PAT)	50	77	78	64	85	107	156	214	282	333
PAT Margins (%)	5.8	7.9	7.1	5.4	6.6	8.6	11	12.2	13.5	13.9
Financial Position:										
Fixed Assets (Net)	239	251	243	371	257	250	295	512	379	465
Current Assets, Loans & Advances	344	412	393	504	522	340	408	471	640	774
Current Liabilities & Provisions	83	108	158	183	241	294	400	436	452	732
Net Working Capital	260	304	235	322	281	46	8	35	189	42
Days of Sales	110	113	78	98	80	14	2	7	33	6
Total Assets	556	609	558	705	640	433	543	624	670	749
Share Capital	29	29	29	29	29	29	29	57	86	86
Reserves & Surplus	233	292	334	365	388	257	335	440	393	531
Shareholder Funds	262	320	362	393	417	286	364	497	480	618
Loan Funds	295	289	196	304	964	132	164	121	160	99
Total Capital Employed	556	609	558	705	640	433	543	624	670	749
RoCE (%)	15.1	17	19.5	12.6	16.1	28.6	31.3	39	45.7	47.7
RONW (%)	19.9	24.7	22	16.6	20.6	38.1	43.5	46.1	61.3	55.3
Equity Share Data:										
Earnings Per Share (INR)	17.6	27.1	2.7	2.3	3	3.7	5.4	3.7	3.3	3.9
Dividend Per Share (INR)	5	10	1	0.5	1.4	2	2.5	1.8	1.42	1.5
No of Shares (tens of millions)	2.9	2.9	28.5	28.6	28.6	28.6	28.6	57.3	86.3	86.4

Source: Dabur India 2007-2008 Annual Report, <https://www.dabur.com/in/en-us/investor/financial-information/reports/annual-reports>.

Note: Sales are Gross Sales i.e Net off Sales tax/VAT paid.

^a Stock split from Rs 10/share to Rs 1/ share

^b Consolidated results from FY02 onwards

^c Dabur Pharma got de-merged.

^d Bonus issue of 1:1 was issued during the year

^e Bonus issue of 1:2 was issue during the year

Exhibit 9 Dabur Ten-Year Financials (2009-2018)

Dabur Financials (in tens of millions of INR)	FY09	FY10	FY11^a	FY12	FY13	FY14	FY15	FY16	FY17	FY18
Financial Results										
Revenue from Operations	2807	3403	4105	5305	6169	7094	7827	7869	7701	7748
Other Income	33	35	32	57	109	128	158	217	298	305
Operating Profit	474	642	800	890	987	1179	1305	1518	1509	1617
Operating Margins (%)	16.9	18.9	19.5	16.8	16	16.6	16.7	19.3	19.6	20.9
Profit Before Tax (PBT)	433	601	708	790	948	1155	1308	1554	1611	1693
Taxes	46	100	139	146	183	219	251	300	330	335
Tax Rate (%)	10.5	16.7	19.6	18.5	19.3	19	19.2	19.3	20.5	19.8
Profit After Tax (PAT)	388	501	569	645	763	933	1055	1251	1277	1354
PAT Margins (%)	13.8	14.7	13.9	12.1	12.4	13.2	13.5	15.9	16.6	17.5
Financial Position										
Net Fixed Assets (incl. Goodwill)	559	677	1531	1668	1674	1789	1927	1773	2001	2070
Current Assets, Loans & Advances	951	1106	4171	2315	2689	3056	2731	3229	3126	3453
Current Liabilities & Provisions	805	920	1458	1384	1414	1887	1942	2169	2278	2491
Share Capital	87	87	174	174	174	174	176	176	176	176
Reserves & Surplus	732	848	1217	1543	1921	2482	3178	3995	4671	5530
Shareholders Funds	819	935	1391	1717	2095	2656	3354	4171	4847	5707
Equity Share Data										
Earnings Per Share (INR)	4.5	5.8	3.3	3.7	4.4	5.2	6.1	7.1	7.2	7.7
Dividend Per Share (INR)	1.8	2	1.2	1.3	1.5	1.8	2	2.3	2.3	7.5
Book Value per Share (INR)	9.5	10.8	8	9.9	12	15.2	19.1	23.7	27.5	32.4
No of Shares (tens of millions)	86.5	86.9	174.1	174.2	174.3	174.4	175.7	175.9	176.2	176.2
Share Price, unadjusted (INR)	99	159	96	106	137	180	266	250	277	327
Market Cap (tens of millions of INR)	8538	13782	16722	18536	23887	31310	46653	43961	48856	57602

Source: Dabur India 2017-2018 Annual Report, <https://www.dabur.com/in/en-us/investor/financial-information/reports/annual-reports>.

^a Bonus Issue of 1:1 during the year.

Share price and market capitalisation as on end of fiscal FY18 is as per IndAS and takes into account GST.

FY16 and FY17 are as per IndAS.

FY08 to FY15 is basis IGAAP.

Exhibit 10 Dabur's Board of Directors in 1997

Name	Role	Outside Director Background
Mr. A.C. Burman	Chairman	
Mr. R.C. Burman	Chairman Emeritus	
Mr. V.C. Burman	Managing Director	
Mr. G.C. Burman	Managing Director	
Air Chief Marshal N.C. Suri	Director	Chief of Air Staff, Indian Air Force
Mr. Ashok Goenka	Director	
Mr. Sidharth Burman	Director	
Mr. Pradip Burman	Director	Dabur; Ayurved, Ltd.
Maharaja Gaj Singh	Director	MP, Indian Parliament; High Commissioner, Indian Foreign Service
Dr. Anand Burman	Director	
Mr. Uday S. Kotak	Director	CEO, Kotak Mahindra Bank
Raja Vijay Karan	Director	Director, Central Bureau of Investigation; Commissioner of Police, Delhi
Mr. Amit Roy	Executive Director (Production)	
Mr. P.D. Narang	Executive Director (Finance)	

Source: Dabur India 1996-1997 Annual Report.

Exhibit 11 Dabur's Board of Directors in 2018

Name	Role	Outside Director Background
Dr. Anand C. Burman	Chairman (Non-Executive/Promoter Director)	
Mr. Amit Burman	Vice Chairman (Non-Executive/Promoter Director)	
Mr. Mohit Burman	Non-Executive/Promoter Director	
Mr. Saket Burman	Non-Executive/Promoter Director	
Mr. P.D. Narang	Executive Director	
Mr. Sunil Duggal	Executive Director	
Mr. P.N. Vijay	Independent Director	CEO, PN Vijay Financial Services
Mr. R.C. Bhargava	Independent Director	CEO, Maruti Suzuki
Dr. S. Narayan	Independent Director	Economic Adviser to the Prime Minister of India
Dr. Ajay Dua	Independent Director	Secretary of Industrial Policy and Promotion, Ministry of Commerce and Industry
Mr. Sanjay Kumar Bhattacharyya	Independent Director	Managing Director, State Bank of India
Mrs. Falguni Sanjay Nayar	Independent Director	CEO, Nykaa.com

Source: Dabur India 1996-1997 Annual Report.

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